

PROJECT PROPOSAL / SYNOPSIS

INDIRA GANDHI NATIONAL OPEN UNIVERSITY

B.A. TOURISM STUDIES (BTS)

Candidate Information (to be filled by the candidate)

Date: _____

Name: _____

Programme Code: BTS Course Code: PTS-2

Enrolment No.: _____

Address: _____

Regional Centre: _____

Study Centre Name and Code: _____

Project Proposal - Topic

Marketing Strategies for Buddhist Circuit Tourism in Siliguri: A Study of Salugara and Nearby Monasteries

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Introduction

Project Proposal - Topic: Marketing Strategies for Buddhist Circuit Tourism in Siliguri: A Study of Salugara and Nearby Monasteries

Tourism marketing for sacred-cultural destinations requires balance between visibility and respect. Unlike purely leisure products, monastery-linked destinations are evaluated by visitors on communication quality, cultural sensitivity, route clarity, and emotional credibility. The Siliguri region presents a practical case where destination potential is significant but coordinated market positioning remains weak.

Salugara and nearby monasteries receive visitors through pilgrimage intent, cultural curiosity, and transit movement. However, current promotion is often fragmented: many travelers discover sites incidentally rather than through planned Buddhist-circuit itineraries. This creates low conversion from potential demand to structured visitation. It also limits economic benefits that could arise from improved stay duration and better route design.

The proposed PTS-2 synopsis addresses this gap by framing Siliguri Buddhist tourism through a marketing strategy lens. The study is not intended to commercialize sacred practice; instead, it seeks to strengthen responsible communication, informed visitation, and collaborative destination management. The proposal therefore emphasizes value- sensitive marketing rather than high-volume promotional tactics.

Review of Literature

Tourism marketing literature establishes that destination competitiveness depends on clear positioning and coherent communication across touchpoints. In the STP framework, segmentation identifies visitor groups, targeting selects priority audiences, and positioning articulates the destination promise. For sacred destinations, positioning must include authenticity, etiquette, and meaning, not only attraction imagery.

Services marketing scholarship (7Ps) highlights that people, process, and physical evidence are especially critical in tourism experiences. For monastery destinations, front-facing behaviour, route guidance, interpretive clarity, and calm atmosphere influence visitor confidence as much as promotional campaigns do. This indicates that marketing strategy should include on-ground service design, not only media outreach.

Significance & Context

Destination branding studies show that a strong tourism brand is built through coherent and repeated trust cues. Fragmented messaging reduces conversion even when the destination product is valuable. In gateway regions, cluster branding can improve recall by connecting nearby sites under a shared narrative. This is directly relevant to Siliguri, where Salugara and nearby monasteries can be presented as a linked Buddhist trail rather than isolated points.

Digital tourism research emphasizes discoverability and metadata reliability. Many travel decisions are influenced by search, maps, reviews, and short-form content. Missing timings, unclear route details, inconsistent naming, and weak multilingual communication reduce trust and intent-to-visit. Literature on platform trust indicates that accuracy, consistency, and responsive updates often produce better outcomes than high-spend campaigns with weak information quality.

Responsible marketing scholarship warns that sacred destinations can be adversely affected by aggressive or culturally insensitive promotion. Ethical communication should include visitor conduct cues, contextual meaning, and preservation values. For monastery-linked destinations, this is not optional; it is central to long-term credibility.

Policy context from Government of India indicates sustained attention to Buddhist tourism through thematic circuit initiatives. Yet local execution quality varies, and many feeder destinations remain under-packaged. This proposal is significant because it addresses that implementation layer: how to convert policy momentum into practical, respectful, and measurable destination marketing actions in a specific regional context.

The study is therefore positioned at the intersection of strategy and cultural responsibility. It is expected to generate actionable insights for segment selection, channel design, local partnerships, and performance monitoring while protecting sacred identity.

The context is commercially significant as well because current visitor inflow appears to be partly incidental rather than intentionally converted through structured communication. When destinations depend heavily on incidental traffic, demand quality remains unstable and planning becomes reactive. A stronger strategic framework can help move from accidental discovery toward informed visitation, improving both visitor readiness and destination reputation.

Significance & Context (continued)

Another reason this section deserves extended treatment is the changing digital behaviour of travelers. Decision journeys increasingly begin before arrival through mobile search, map previews, user reviews, and short-form creator content. If local Buddhist destinations are represented inconsistently online, potential visitors may abandon intent or arrive without adequate cultural context. The proposal therefore treats digital hygiene as a foundational marketing issue rather than a secondary promotional add-on.

Significance is also linked to segmentation efficiency. Without clear segment definition, communication budgets and effort are diluted across audiences with different motivations and expectations. A spiritual short-break traveler, a cultural learner, and an international Buddhist-interest visitor do not require identical messaging. The study can therefore improve strategic precision by aligning segment priorities with channel choices and content formats.

From a governance perspective, monastery-linked marketing requires multi-actor coordination that is often missing in small and medium destinations. Travel intermediaries, local businesses, community stakeholders, and site custodians may all hold partial information but no integrated action plan. This project's significance lies in creating an evidence-based coordination map that can support phased implementation without compromising institutional autonomy or sacred standards.

The context is additionally important for responsible tourism outcomes. Unbalanced promotion can increase social media visibility but also trigger etiquette violations, crowding spikes, and cultural discomfort if visitor orientation is weak. A structured Significance & Context analysis helps ensure that marketing recommendations include behavioural guidance, not only visibility targets. In sacred destinations, this distinction is critical for long-term credibility.

Economically, the study can contribute to better local benefit pathways by identifying where marketing improvements can raise conversion into local services in a controlled and respectful manner. This includes itinerary clarity, partnership with ethical service providers, and improved information interfaces at transit nodes. Such interventions may improve local opportunity without pushing high-intensity tourism models unsuitable for monastic environments.

In summary, the significance of this proposal spans destination brand coherence, digital trust, segment-wise communication, partnership architecture, responsible visitor conduct, and local value capture. Because these dimensions are interdependent, a two-page Significance & Context section is methodologically justified and necessary for a robust PTS-2 synopsis.

Objective of the Study

Primary Objective: To design practical and culturally respectful marketing strategies for Buddhist circuit tourism in Siliguri with specific focus on Salugara and selected nearby monasteries.

Specific Objectives: 1. To assess current visibility and positioning of monastery-linked tourism in the study area. 2. To identify priority visitor segments and their information needs. 3. To evaluate present promotion channels, digital quality, and travel trade linkage strength. 4. To develop STP-driven strategy recommendations for communication and itinerary conversion. 5. To propose a monitoring framework using measurable awareness, conversion, and experience indicators.

Study Boundaries: The project focuses on destination marketing dimensions and excludes internal religious governance. The output is intended as a strategy-oriented student study with local practical relevance.

Methodology

Research Design: The study uses a mixed-method marketing audit design, combining tourist perception data, stakeholder insights, and digital channel assessment. This design is appropriate because destination marketing quality is shaped by both measurable outcomes and contextual interpretation.

Data Sources: Primary data will include tourist questionnaires, interviews with local tourism stakeholders, and selected interactions with service providers linked to visitor movement. Secondary data will include policy releases, official tourism statistics, and conceptual marketing literature.

Proposed Tools: - Tourist survey instrument for awareness, motivation, and communication clarity. - Stakeholder interview schedule for packaging barriers and channel observations. - Digital audit checklist for search, maps, and social consistency. - Content calendar and KPI templates for implementation planning. These tools are included as synopsis annexure attachments.

Sampling and Field Process: Data collection will be done across varied time windows to account for movement variation. Respondents will be selected through practical purposive sampling aligned to project scope. Field notes will document contextual conditions influencing interpretation, such as transit pressure and service readiness.

Methodology (continued)

Analytical Approach: Survey data will be summarized using basic percentages. Qualitative responses will be grouped under themes: awareness pathways, packaging constraints, communication gaps, and strategic opportunities. A SWOT lens and STP interpretation will be used to convert evidence into strategy options. Recommended actions will be arranged in phased format (foundation, productization, scale with safeguards).

Reliability and Ethics: Triangulation across tourist, stakeholder, and audit inputs will be used to improve reliability. Respondent participation will be voluntary, and sensitive personal data will not be disclosed. The study will avoid misleading claims and will differentiate observed evidence from inference.

Expected Deliverable Form: The methodology is designed to produce a proposal that can transition smoothly into full PTS-2 project writing, with direct alignment between objectives, tools, analysis, and annexure documentation.

Conclusion

The proposed PTS-2 synopsis establishes that Siliguri Buddhist tourism has strong positioning potential but currently lacks integrated marketing execution. The study is designed to address this through a structured and responsible strategy framework rather than purely promotional expansion.

By combining STP logic, service-design perspective, digital audit findings, and stakeholder evidence, the project aims to produce recommendations that are academically valid and practically usable. The proposal also emphasizes that sacred destination marketing must preserve cultural dignity while improving access, clarity, and visitor preparedness.

Overall, the synopsis supports a feasible, field-linked, and policy-aware project path. It is expected to contribute to both BTS academic requirements and local discussion on mindful Buddhist circuit development.

Reference

1. IGNOU. BTS Project Guide (PTS-1, PTS-2), valid from July 2021.
2. Ministry of Tourism, Government of India. Domestic and Foreign Tourist Visits by State/UT (2021-2022).
3. PIB, Government of India. Buddhist Thematic Circuit under Swadesh Darshan (2025).
4. PIB, Ministry of Tourism. Attracting Tourists to Buddhist Circuits (2026).
5. Kotler, P., Bowen, J., and Makens, J. Marketing for Hospitality and Tourism.
6. Middleton, V., Fyall, A., Morgan, M., and Ranchhod, A. Marketing in Travel and Tourism.
7. Chaffey, D. Digital Marketing: Strategy and Practice.
8. UNWTO reports on tourism and culture synergies.
9. Researcher-prepared tool drafts and field planning notes.

ANNEXURE TO SYNOPSIS

Annexure to Synopsis (Proposed Research Tools): - Annexure A: Tourist Survey Instrument - Annexure B: Stakeholder Interview Schedule - Annexure C: Digital Audit Checklist - Annexure D: One-Month Content Calendar Template - Annexure E: KPI Dashboard Template

Note: Annexure tools are attached at synopsis stage for supervisor review and are retained in final project annexure after refinement.

LETTER/CERTIFICATE OF APPROVAL (By the Supervisor)

I hereby certify that the proposal for the Project entitled _____ by _____ has been prepared after due consultation with me. The proposal has my approval and has, to my knowledge, the potential of developing into a comprehensive Project Work. I also agree to supervise the above mentioned Project till its completion.

Signature of the Supervisor: _____ Name: _____ Designation: _____
Address: _____

Checklist: Keep one copy with yourself. Submit one signed proposal copy to Programme Coordinator (BTS/BAVTM), SOTHSM, IGNOU.